together. This time the Congress is having to deal with a tough, dynamic politician who has understood what it takes not just to win power but to retain it, as he has shown in Gujarat. Challenging him will require the Congress to move beyond its time-worn slogans and identify more directly with the aspirations of a younger, more impatient India.

For example, the Congress's vision of a secular republic now faces a mounting challenge even from its traditional supporters. At a seminar in Patna, a young Muslim student leader told senior academic Pratap Bhanu Mehta that he had three questions he wished to pose to Rahul. 'I want to know, are Muslim youth less likely to suffer ordinary discrimination in Congress-ruled states? Does a Congress-ruled state like Assam or Delhi have a better record of bringing perpetrators of riots to justice? Why, after sixty years of Congress rule, do Muslims feel they have to vote on their "security"?'

The three sharply worded questions reflect the dilemma of the Indian Muslim—is 'secular blackmail' stemming from the fear of a Modi-led government enough reason to vote for a party which itself has failed to offer protection or development to minorities? The Congress cannot rely on handouts and platitudes any longer; it needs to be ready to start a mass mobilization programme by taking up issues of urgent public concern. The era of drawing-room political machinations is coming to an end. It would be premature to write the obituary of any party, but the Congress does have a long, arduous road ahead.

Other parties, too, are having to slowly pick up the pieces after the stunning 2014 results. In Bihar, we have seen the emergence of a potential grand 'secular alliance'—Nitish, Lalu and the Congress may actually come together in the 2015 assembly elections. It's an alliance which smacks of political opportunism—once sworn enemies are coming together in a desperate bid to keep the BJP out. As Lalu told me, 'Our biggest enemy is Narendra Modi. *Bade dushman ko harane ke liye kabhi kabhi samjhauta karna padta hai*' (To defeat a bigger enemy, you sometimes have to compromise). If the Bihar by-election results are any evidence, then Lalu's instinctive street-smart politics is a potential survival ticket.